family dramas, loves, hierarchies, and power structures. And Gulbadan is the only chronicler to write candidly and unselfconsciously of the unexpected and influential roles of women. She is the only writer, for example, to record events such as Khanzada Begum's diplomatic mission to Kamran on Humayun's behalf, and the moral authority this elderly matriarch wielded in the name of Padshah Babur himself. She writes about the determined wooing of Hamida Banu by Humayun that was equally stoutly resisted by the unimpressed bride for forty days.

Many of the incidents Gulbadan wrote about she would have discussed with Hamida Banu, and she often refers to Hamida Banu's memories in her writing. So we have the shadowy recording of various women's voices in this unique document. And in complete contrast to the ossified and sequestered space that Abu'l Fazl would write about in a few years, Gulbadan writes of a harem continuously on the move, of women on horseback, of women journeying and living in tents, and sharing the struggles and the victories of their men. Her tale is replete with the accounts of births while on the move, marriages of temperamental or forthright brides, the detailing of gifts as symbols of a Padshah's love, and tender remembrance. According to Ruby Lal, through Gulbadan's writing, 'we have a lost world of the court in camp brought to life in a way that no other chronicle of the time even approaches'.

Abu'l Fazl, meanwhile, would spend the next few years questioning Akbar's old family retainers and relatives, to record their memories of Babur, Humayun and, especially, of Akbar himself. 'I spoke to old and young men of right character', asserts Abu'l Fazl firmly, after which accounts were drawn up and then read out to the Padshah every day. The Padshah listened closely to these accounts and corrected the mistakes as he saw fit. Abu'l Fazl consulted the records office, farmans issued by Akbar, petitions filed by ministers, in addition to listening to the oral records of trustworthy persons including, notably, those of his own father, and of the emperor himself. The result of this enormous labour of research and compilation would be two gargantuan works—a history of Akbar's reign and his times, called the *Akbarnama* in two volumes, and an equally voluminous gazetteer, the *Ain-i Akbari*, which was a detailed compendium of imperial regulations, as well as information on the geography, social and religious customs, and administration of the land. The *Ain-i Akbari* was a unique document for its time and would serve as a model for future